

Carnal ethnography

Description of the game

When I was little, my time spent on Papa's Freezeria amounted to an obsession.

Papa's Freezeria is a simulation game, created by Flipline Studios, an American game development company best known for their series of Papa Louie restaurant management games. Many different games are available: at a Pizzeria, Freezeria, Taco restaurant, Burger restaurant, Pancakes restaurant, etc. So, when I saw that the studio updated the 2011 game for a new deluxe version in 2023, I decided to pick it up again. In Papa's Freezeria, players run an ice cream shop on a tropical island. Players must take orders from customers and work through four stations : the *order station* in which you take orders ; the *build station* in which you dispense ice cream in the right cup size with the correct flavors ; the *mix station* in which you blend the ice cream to the desired consistency ; the *top station* in which you add the whipped cream, syrup and toppings requested. Each day is timed, and therefore, players must manage time efficiently. They need to ensure each sundae is made to perfection, based on the customer's specifications, but also have to fight against the clock so customers do not complain. Successes and high scores earn tips and boosts the shop's popularity, while mistakes lead to lower scores and unhappy customers. And day after day, the orders are taken faster, the bonuses bought with my week's pay makes the preparation easier, and the complexity of the tasks increases. New ingredients, more demanding customers, and tighter time constraints turn each day into a harder one than yesterday. The game's challenge lies in juggling multiple tasks simultaneously while maintaining accuracy and speed in the orders.

Physical embodiment & Mastery

I click on the home button "start", fingers twitching at the anticipation. Once I do, colors explode at my face and my eyes startle a little bit from the sudden lightning in the middle of the night. The screen is saturated with bright hues — bubblegum pinks, lemon yellows, and mint greens — that feel almost too babyish. This childish design also feels reassuring, reminding me of the nostalgia of playing this game on my father's computer. The characters, too, resemble a cartoon series with their oversized heads, huge smiles and tiny necks. Even the ice cream ingredients are hyper-stylized, with whipped cream that look like clouds or the toppings that remind me of a child's toy. Every detail feels like it is here on purpose to evoke childhood, being more concerned with fun than any realism.

However, this childlike content is surprisingly intense. The cute colors and whimsical designs put the player into a fake sense of comfort, and it masks the stressful mechanics that follow. It's as if the game is saying, "Don't worry, it's all just for fun," while increasing the pressure every day that passes.

One order done; I must check the blender. A smoothie is almost about to reach its desired consistency, I will have to remember this in 7 seconds. In the meantime, I assemble the ingredients of a new order. My grip on the mouse tightens reflexively as I am about to click on the exact flavor. The machine ticks down, and I can see my tension rise up as the cursor arrives on the right button, like a visual embodiment of my heartbeat going faster. Click. Success. I let out a big breath and release the tension I did not even realize I was holding this entire time. But resting is not possible yet; the timer blinks in the corner, the bell rings as new customers arrive, and all these sounds I hear succeed in not allowing a single foreign thought to pass my mind. The world outside of the game begins to fade: I become entirely absorbed in its rhythm. Indeed, the music in this game lasts exactly 8 seconds, notes that are being repeated in an infinite loop, but I never get tired of it. I do not even notice it being repeated, I fully only realized it when writing this paper, even after years of playing the same game.

Success and failure are immediately notified: a perfectly layered base earns a satisfying “ting!”, and a failed one stays silent. I cannot help but feel a rush of happiness at each rewarding sound, just like a Pavlovian dog responding to a bell. My pulse quickens, and I feel utterly excited when having a perfect streak: I become hyper-focused, my mind feels cloudy, until my excitement falls back... I received a 99% rating instead of 100%. I failed everything. Sometimes, I feel the *need* to restart the entire day at the simple sight of a minor error. Perfection is not something to attain, but something required.

The more time spent on this game, the more I feel my movements become more natural, and almost instinctive. As Pierre Bourdieu (1977, p.86) might observe, I am acquiring a kind of “habitus” of a virtual freeze maker, in which a set of disposition guide my actions without me consciously having to think about it. When a customer arrives, I no longer need to analyze their order for long seconds to get it right. My eyes move quickly across the screen, and my body reacts automatically: mouse to dispenser, a measured click to perfection, a practiced drag to the next station. My mind is no longer occupied by efforts and pauses, but instead, it is almost like completely shut down. At one point, I do not feel like playing anymore, but I feel like I am now an employee of the store myself. This is not all just for fun anymore. My body, my mind, and the game all become a singular system of actions in which everything just imbricates perfectly to make sense. This is not just the acquisition of a skill; it is the embodiment of a habitus of a simulation of a freeze service job.

Psychological impact

After having spent so much time on this game, one would think I would feel satisfied. After all, I mastered the controls, finished day 100 and all the successes on Steam. But I would argue the complete opposite: I felt that more than ever, I needed more. And then, on the next day, I had to go to work to complete the next mission: my professional life. Indeed, while I was working at a Smoothie-making place, I found myself enjoying the task because of its similarities with my cherished Papa’s game. And apparently, I was not the only one: on TikTok is a famous trend of users filming themselves making a drink for a customer, while being employed at a similar company, with the music of Papa’s Freezeria main theme in the background. (Figure 1) They implied that their job did not *feel* like a job because it was so fun, like playing a Papa’s Game would be. Some users even labeled their job “Papa’s Freezeria IRL”.



Figure 1: TikTok video from user @helmi.niem1 comparing a task at their work to the game Papa's Freezeria, as seen with the background music from the game and the hashtag #papasfreezeria

When playing this game, I was always so excited to get to payday on the 7th day of each week so I could buy clothes and accessories that would make my freeze-making business even more efficient. It transferred into real-life, like when I had to wait for my first paycheck after two weeks to finally be able to buy myself comfortable shoes to improve my workdays and make my smoothie-making skills more efficient to not slack off at work.

This connection between play and labor can be linked to Foucault's concept of the "entrepreneur of the self", where individuals internalize the logic of constant optimization of their skills and self-improvement. (Foucault, 1976) In Papa's Freezeria, the game's mechanics really encourage perfectionism and efficiency, for which the player starts to see these traits as satisfying, and furthermore, necessary. Their extension to real life is not surprising, as this need for reward for perfectionism extends outside of the game; for example, with my job, in which play and labor blended in this entrepreneurial framework. The aesthetics and overall rhythm of the game make structured labor feel enjoyable and even sometimes playful, as the TikTok users were pointing out. The game trains players not only to play to perform the action of play, but to play to constantly improve their skills to optimize each one of their actions, in order to optimise themselves.

Reflecting on my experience with *Papa's Freezeria*, it becomes clear to me that this "simple" simulation game is not that simple and extends far beyond the screen. The game's mechanics do more than just entertain the player; they entertain ideas from society of the need for constant self-optimization to align with the values of the market. I truly embody this service job, from both the way my body has learnt to move my fingers to master the game, and from the way my mind conditioned me to take enjoyment and striving to become better at a job that would pay me less than living wage.